

Karen Jia

Mrs. Breakall

English 8 Advanced

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The Weight of Loving

A woman leaned against the foggy window, letting out a shaky breath that she hadn't even noticed she was holding in. She could barely make out the imposing sign of that set of sad, sullen letters that stared unblinkingly back at her. *MUNICH BANHOF*, it read. Whether it was blurry because of the window or her tears, she couldn't tell.

The train started, and her mind flashed back.

A sobbing girl clawed desperately at her mother's woolen coat, the already-worn texture beginning to come apart.

The mother reached down and grabbed the small, shaking wrist with such intensity that the girl went still. In that moment, the mother's heart shattered into a million pieces. Could her daughter feel the love that it came from? Or would she grow to hate her for it? How she longed to soften her grip in that moment, to smooth out the girl's messed up hair and rub her frightened, tear-stained cheeks.

Instead, she thrust the small hand down.

It's all I can do, my darling.

I'm sorry.

The woman couldn't even kiss her goodbye. She couldn't even get one last glance. She couldn't bear to.

☐ ☐ ☐ A RECURRING THEME IN MY ALBUMS ☐ ☐ ☐

**All mothers must accept the inevitable:
that one day, she will have to let her child go.
But no mother ever imagines letting go like this.**

And now the woman was tormenting herself. She was swimming through an ocean of obsidian, her heavy wool coat swallowing her whole. I know this because I was right there, watching from the murky swamp of her guilt.

She wanted me to take her. How I, too, wished to free her from the suffering, to take her with me right then and there. But that was against the rules. *Soon*, I wanted to assure her. *Soon you'll be free.*

And after what seemed like all of eternity, she surfaced.

The wind cut its freezing blades into her cheeks, berating her for her negligence. She took it. Two officers in matching uniforms were ushering the crowd off the train, dividing them between men, women, and children. Families torn apart. Screaming. Crying. Perhaps the woman did at least one thing right, saving the pain of separation for sooner rather than later.

"Disinfection" was what they were told as the breathing corpses removed their belongings and clothing. Breathing corpses. That's what they were, really. Walking into their own graves.

As the book thief's mother removed the wool coat from her shoulders, the emptiness it left behind felt unnatural. Although the material was already worn and shabby, it nevertheless offered a protection that was now all but gone.

It was only a matter of time before the silent shrieking– the souls of sisters, daughters, mothers, begging me to take them. I tried working as efficiently as I could, but you could only go so fast squeezing through a room of packed bodies.

The book thief's mother was one of the two thousand souls that I took away that day in that awful chamber. By the time I retrieved her, she was glowing a faint yellow, still slightly warm as I rested her upon my shoulder.

Later, I would find myself coming back for more and more rounds.

I truly believe that if she had to do it all over again, she would have changed nothing. Choosing her daughter's life over her own pride, that was love in its most heartbreaking form.

To this day, I remember the weight of the wool coat more than I remember her face. Perhaps it was the sympathy for the mother that led me to keep an eye out for the little book thief back on Himmel Street.